DEEP WORK

How to Wake Up Without Killing the Dream

Conspiracy cartoons, culture-as-OS, and why beauty may be the only compas
still works

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Conspiracy theories are epistemological cartoons; comfort-food cosmologies f
the plot gets weird. It's soothing to believe there's a steering committee behin
curtain: the Grays, the Masons, the Vatican, the World Bank, "the elites," pick
villain. A tidy diagram, a closed loop, an explanation you can hold like a talisn
real terror is far less cinematic: **no one is in control**.

History behaves less like a board meeting and more like a dream: emergent, sy
driven by nonlinear dynamics we imagine we understand because they look ti
hindsight. Yes, there are actors seeking control (that's what actors do), but the

throws the control freak against the wall every decade or so. Try to command a
and you wake up with teeth full of air.

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receive new posts and support my work.

So how do we live; ethically, intelligently, and creatively inside a planetary sto
neither random noise nor secretly scripted? How do we *wake up* without killin
dream that actually keeps us human?

> Let's start with where our attention lives.

There's a razor-thin seam between waking and sleep called hypnagogia where
mind loosens, images surge, pattern blooms, and the laws of physics still most
That seam is a good metaphor for adult consciousness in a crisis century. We
both modes at once:

- **Awake:** the realm where hurled objects shatter, electricity shocks, and phy
keeps its appointments. This is bill-pay, seatbelts, lab notebooks, consent
reality that doesn't care about your vibe.
- **Dream:** the realm where synchrony whispers, archetypes stride, and the "
giggle" breaks through the drywall. This is myth, poetics, sudden meaning
pattern that teaches before it proves.

Gurdjieff said people are asleep. The modern addendum is crueller: we're
over-stimulated and under-awakened. The cure isn't to pick one mode and sn
the other; it's to cultivate the interface. "While sleeping, watch." Keep your eye
physics while you court the Muse.

The Balkanization of Knowing

Open your window and you'll hear a dozen realities shouting over each other. Quantum mystics next to angel channelers. Genomicists across the hall from flat-earthers. Econometricians sharing a wall with astrocartographers. This is pluralism; it's a **balkanized epistemology**; mutually incompatible operating sy running on adjacent human hardware.

The metaphor isn't cute; it's diagnostic. **Cultures are operating systems.** The biological wetware (our brains, same basic model for ~100,000 years) hasn't ch

much. What we boot into has. One OS specializes in animist kinship and fish
another in continuous integration and Kubernetes clusters; both call themselv
"reality." They're not equally predictive, but they're equally convincing to thei
That matters.

Science is the solitary OS that awards points for proving itself wrong. You pub
paper A, do the work, retract A, publish B, and your reputation improves. Tha
humility scaffold (falsifiability, replication, error bars) isn't a religion; it's a hy
Keep it precious. But don't confuse **method** with **monopoly**. There are forms c
meaning (beauty, myth, eros, initiation) that don't submit to p-values and still
lives.

Culture Is Not Your Friend (But It Is Your Starter Pack)

Culture does two very useful things and then one very dangerous one:

1. **Useful:** It hands you quick-start myths so you don't have to build cosmolo
raw ore when you're eight.
2. **Useful:** It supplies etiquette and coordination so we can share sidewalks v
spears.
3. **Dangerous:** It persuades you to never grow past the starter kit.

Evolution has a term for arrested development: **neoteny**. It is the condition of
traits retained into adulthood. Culture can be a neotenizing force, keeping us
with prefabricated answers long after we're old enough to know better. One of
modernity's great side effects is that we live long enough to see through the co
We realize on some level the game is not worth the candle. Alienation is what

the week you finally notice the zipper on the back of the mascot.

That's not the end of the world; it's the beginning of responsibility.

For example, Orwell's nightmare is a boot on the face. Everyone recognizes th oppression. You can smell the enemy.

Huxley's nightmare, however, is more sophisticated: **a society so comfortable forgets how to want anything real.** Not terror, but *satisfaction*. Not censorship substitution. Not chains, but **soma**: a technology of mood that turns existentia questions into a minor scheduling inconvenience.

That's the weird thing about the current century: our censorship doesn't have books. It just has to **make books feel like too much effort**. It doesn't have to o meaning. It just has to flood the zone with frictionless dopamine until meanin like an artisanal hobby.

In that world, the most powerful political instrument isn't propaganda; it's **pre shaping**. A system that can nudge what you crave can govern you without eve its voice. It can let you keep your opinions as long as it owns your attention, b attention is the upstream currency of everything else: will, discipline, tendern memory, courage.

This is why conspiracy theories are such perfect soma. They give you the plea coherence without the labor of truth. They offer moral theater (heroes and vill you can experience righteousness without doing repair. They are snackable apocalypse: calories of meaning, zero nutrition, high certainty, and the lovely of "at least I'm not one of the sheep."

But the real Brave New World move is subtler: it's not that you believe the wr thing. It's that you become **incapable of sustained contact with any thing**, tru

false, because sustained contact feels uncomfortable. Because you've been trai
gently, to treat discomfort as an error state. Because you're living inside a pala
immediate relief.

An adult civilization cannot be built by people who cannot endure a moment o
boredom.

So: if we're going to live ethically inside a weird story, we have to reclaim a ve
spiritual practice with an extremely modern interface:

fasting from cheap comfort.

Not as punishment. As sovereignty.

Not because pleasure is evil. But because pleasure is *programmable*, and some o
not yours. Some of it is delivered to keep you docile, spendy, and predictable. S
it is there to keep you from touching the seam between waking and dream, be
that seam produces inconvenient humans: humans who can feel beauty, grief,
and love without asking permission.

Huxley's warning wasn't "beware tyrants."

It was: **beware a civilization that turns the human soul into a customer supp
ticket.**

The boot and the lullaby are not opposites; they're cousins. Both forms of pow
to govern **the channel**, not the conclusion, because if I can shape what you *no*
don't have to fight you about what you *believe*. The modern state doesn't need
outlaw meaning; it just needs to keep you too stimulated to sustain contact wi
Which means the real battleground isn't ideology. Its **interface** is the substrat
attention gets assigned, emotion gets primed, and reality gets rendered.

And the oldest interface we have is also the most overlooked: *language*. Not as
but as the firmware that turns raw sensation into a world you can inhabit.

Language Is the Original VR.

There's a particular flavor of late-modern paranoia that doesn't even need alie
bankers. It's quieter, more plausible, more humiliating:

The Truman Show feeling.

Not "I am the chosen one" paranoia. The opposite. The sense that you're ordi
enough to be manipulated, but important enough to be measured. That your li

become a soft set where the props are real, the emotions are real, and the *cont* choice are gently pre-curved by someone else's invisible hand.

In the film, Truman's tragedy is not surveillance in the abstract. It's the **betray context**. Every relationship is "real," except for the small detail that it is a job. coincidence is "random," except for the small detail that it was scheduled. He physics, but he can't trust meaning. And when meaning becomes untrustwortl mind does the obvious thing: it starts pattern-matching like a starving animal.

The modern twist is that our world does not require a dome.

We carry the cameras, buy the microphones, and politely sign the release form it comes with free shipping. Nobody has to script the scene when the incentiv gradient does the scripting for them. You don't need a director if you have a dashboard. You don't need a cabal if you have a business model that rewards c attention more than it rewards telling the truth.

And the danger is not merely that we're watched.

The danger is that **we begin to perform for the watcher inside our own skull.** narrating ourselves instead of inhabiting ourselves. We become our own produ trimming the messy parts, cropping out doubt, smoothing the edge of grief in something postable. A person can survive being observed. What a person cann survive indefinitely is being turned into a character in their own life.

The escape hatch is the one Truman discovers the hard way: not "expose the v but **touch the wall**. Find the seam where the set ends and the real begins: the l local, the stubborn physicality of things that don't care who's watching. The o has teeth. Gravity remains rude. Your child still needs you at 3 a.m. in a way n narrative can fake.

That's how you don't go insane in a world that feels staged.

Not by insisting there must be a writer.

By remembering there may only be **a machine that optimizes**, and you are allo
step out of its preferred storyline.

Reality Has an API.

If the 20th century gave us one durable insight, it's this: **information is more fundamental than matter.** Code, pattern, relation; these are the bedrock. "The made of language" isn't a stoner bumper sticker; it's a serious claim about inte Spoken story around a fire is virtual reality. Cathedrals are VR in stone. A city that bills you monthly.

Treat reality as an **API** and you will behave differently:

- You stop demanding omnipotence and start practicing **ethical hacks**. Sma elegant interventions that change the system without melting it.
- You notice when someone is **root-kitting your attention** with outrage, fla fear.
- You distinguish **noise** (what exhausts without changing you) from **novelty** changes you without exhausting you, see Life EV).

We do not get admin privileges over the cosmos. But we can write better midd for meaning.

Conspiracy stories have three addictive features: a villain you can picture, a pl can track, and a promise that your cynicism makes you wise. The problem isn' conspiracies never happen… they do, *constantly*, at local scales where incentive concentrate. The problem is **scale**. The global system runs on coupled feedbac

perverse incentives, bounded rationality, misaligned goal functions, and laten not a cabal; it's **emergence**. And it's a harder pill to swallow than convenient p over epistemological cartoons to satisfy the metaphysical junkies that we are.

When you upgrade *they* to *that* (from sentient puppet masters to dumb systemi dynamics), you don't get the narcotic payoff of having decoded the hidden pla get something better: **agency that scales**. You can look for leverage points (sta defaults, narratives, margins), not just villains. You can build institutions that gracefully instead of spectacularly. You can stop praying for the indictments t arrive and start doing the work that always awaits.

Ask philosophy for a North Star and you'll get the classical triad: the Good, th and the Beautiful. The first two are slippery on the best day. Moral reasoning famously culture-bound; "truth" got cast as either brute fact or tribal narrative haven't forgiven each other since.

Beauty is different. Not because it's subjective (everything important is), but b **it's legible to the nervous system.**You know when a line is elegant, a proof cle poem inevitable, a building that actually improves your pulse. Beauty is **coher can feel**.

Use it. When models compete, choose the one that is:

- **Simpler than the problem but not insulting.** Elegance without reductioni
- **Generative.** It creates capacity in others, not dependence on you.
- **Relational.** It improves the quality of connection, human-to-human, hum place, human-to-future.
- **Anti-extractive.** It doesn't burn more dignity than it produces insight.
- **Repairable.** When it fails (everything fails), it fails softly.

Beauty, used this way, stops being a garnish and becomes a checksum. It's the system's way of flagging incoherence *before* the spreadsheet catches up—an ea warning system for extraction, contempt, and the kinds of "solutions" that ma smaller while calling it maturity. When we lose that taste, we become easy to s by a moustache-twirling villain, but by any system that can make itself feel ine And that's when the mind reaches for the old sedative—**a face to hate**—becau are simpler than feedback loops, and scapegoats are easier than responsibility

Which brings us to the darker part of the story: the temptation to keep evil "ou so we don't have to admit how portable it is. Beauty won't save us alone. But w it, awakening curdles into despair. Beauty keeps the heart from hardening whi head does hard work.

When the plot gets weird, we crave villains partly because villains keep the da *outside*.

"They did it."

"They are doing it."

"They are coming."

It's psychologically efficient. It lets the nervous system locate the threat and a spear. It's also, very often, a lie we tell ourselves to avoid a more intimate terro

the darkness is not only out there.

Heart of Darkness is not ultimately a story about Africa. It's a story about wha happens when the civilizational costume comes off and a man discovers he ca anything. Kurtz doesn't become monstrous because a secret society hands him manifesto. He becomes monstrous because the environment removes friction:

distance, power, isolation, adoration, silence. The jungle is not an evil cabal; it
context that reveals what was already possible inside him.

Modernity is producing Kurtz-contexts at scale.

A trading desk. A content platform. A surveillance system. A moderation queu
supply chain spreadsheet that turns forests into "inputs." A war room with a la
advantage. A model that optimizes for engagement with no concept of the goo
human (or a machine) into a context where the feedback loops reward extracti
punish empathy, and then act surprised when extraction wins.

That's not a conspiracy. That's physics in moral clothing.

So yes: there are actors seeking control. And there are institutions that behave
hungry organisms. And there are incentives that turn normal people into little
bureaucratic Kurtzes who "just follow policy" while their soul quietly files for
bankruptcy.

If you want an ethical life in that terrain, you must do something both mystica
brutally practical: **you must build friction back in.**

Friction against your worst impulses. Friction against systems that reward
dehumanization. Friction against the story that "if I don't do it, someone else
That's the line Kurtz tells himself right before the abyss starts calling his nam
old friend.

The wake-up is not only "they are lying."

The wake-up is: **I am capable of lying when it profits me.**
I am capable of cruelty when no one is watching.
I am capable of outsourcing responsibility when it feels inconvenient.

This isn't self-flagellation. It's adulthood. It's the condition for building anyth
lasts.

You don't defeat the darkness by hunting phantoms.

You defeat it by designing systems (and selves) that cannot easily become Kurt

To collectively avoid Kurtz' fate, we need to do two incompatible things at onc

1. **Awaken.** Tell the truth about our situation: ecological overshoot, political
derangement, extractive economics, the entire carnival of engineered crav
Ground in physics. Count the costs. Stop doing harm where we can stop t
2. **Dream—on purpose.** Re-enchant the public imagination with stories that
their keep: ritual that dignifies change, myth that enlarges responsibility,
upgrades attention, spaces (both physical and digital) that make it easier t
kind of person you intend to be.

That paradox is not a bug; it's the doorway. Kill the dream and you get brittle '
that collapses at the first strong wind. Ignore the waking world and you get su
spirituality that can't carry water. The work is to hold the seam.

There's a reason improbable lives hinge on ordinary moments; walking into a
the exact wrong time and finding your future sitting there, seeing a face acros
and feeling history reroute. Call it luck if you like. I'll risk the unfashionable w
love.

Not romance as content genre. Love as the field that **breaks statistical indepe**
the coherence that makes certain outcomes more likely than we have any righ
expect. In the physics of human affairs, love acts like an attractor that reorgan
probability around meaning. Is that falsifiable? Not easily. Is it operational?
Absolutely. Love makes better bets because it changes what you're willing to s

If you want the “cosmic giggle,” start by being *worth* it. The field seems to favc who aren’t trying to steal the punchline.

A Field Guide for Sanity in a Cartoon Age

There is a kind of person Dostoevsky diagnosed that the internet later scaled i industry.

The Underground Man is not evil in the cinematic sense. He is *wounded* and *b* and *trapped* in a hall of mirrors where every moral impulse gets reverse-engine into a humiliation. He can’t simply want something. Wanting is naïve. Wantin you get tricked. So he makes an identity out of refusal.

He is the patron saint of the modern comment section.

What makes him dangerous is not his intelligence but his **perverse freedom**: t pleasure of doing the self-defeating thing purely to prove he is not predictable would rather suffer in a way he chose than heal in a way that makes him feel i He would rather be right in his misery than risk being wrong in happiness.

That energy is everywhere now, because it has been monetized.

Outrage is the easiest fuel. Cynicism is the cheapest credential. The reward st says: be the first to sneer, be the quickest to accuse, be the one who spots the f if you can’t fix the world, at least you can *perform* how unfooled you are by it.

But the Underground posture is epistemologically corrosive. It makes you imr propaganda by making you immune to *goodness*. It protects you from being manipulated by protecting you from being moved. It is a vaccination that also patient.

This is why aesthetic discernment matters so much. Not as bourgeois decorati
diagnostic tool.

If a worldview makes you uglier, more contemptuous, more brittle, more addic
humiliation, then whatever "truth" it contains is being *weaponized* against you
humanity. If your certainty tastes like bile, something is wrong. If your politics
requires you to become a worse person to remain "informed," you are not info
you are infected.

The antidote is not naïveté. It's courage.

The courage to be sincere without being gullible.
The courage to update without making it a public self-immolation.
The courage to admit you want things, and to want them cleanly.

The Underground Man is a warning: a person can become so committed to no
fooled that they end up living a life designed by the very forces they claim to d
life built entirely out of reactions is still a life controlled from the outside.

If you want sovereignty, you need the strength to make positive choices.

Not just clever refusals.

A field guide to sovereignty in this environment might look something like:

1. **Model like a scientist, move like a poet.** Hold hypotheses lightly; update
   public; reward disconfirmation. Then communicate in images that make
   responsibility feel like belonging, not punishment.
2. **Upgrade your "they."** When tempted by villain porn, ask: where are the in
   latencies, and feedback loops? Which parts are plots and which parts are
3. **Protect your inputs.** The feed is an IV line. Curate ruthlessly. Outrage is a

calorie.

4. **Practice aesthetic discernment.** If a claim requires you to contort your ta toward ugliness, contempt, or pornographies of certainty—walk away.
5. **Keep a transference detector.** In any altered state (politics, religion, medi psychedelics) watch for the moment you hand someone else your sovereig Take it back with a bow.
6. **Favor institutions that fail soft.** Distributed power, transparent mechanis reversible decisions, small experiments at the edge.
7. **Anchor locally, coordinate globally.** Real control exists where bodies mee there. Use networks to share pattern, not to outsource responsibility.

Most of us in rooms like this are ludicrously privileged by planetary standards terrifyingly close to the control surfaces: product, policy, infrastructure, finan media, code. That proximity is not a guilt; it's an **obligation**. Treat the entire h domain of Earth and near space as a design brief with planetary aesthetic stak

Design for **fit** (with ecosystems), **friction** (with exploitative impulses), and **fide** future beings who can't sue us yet). Put **beauty back in the spec**, not as garnis the ethic by which the true and the good get their marching orders.

Language made cathedrals. Code makes worlds. Choose accordingly.

Whether you speak in math or myth, you can feel history hurrying. Novelty sta novelty; the epochs are getting short. If there is a "transcendental object at th time," it probably doesn't look like a mothership or a throne. It looks like **cohe** an inflection point where relation organizes at a higher order than the brute e imagine.

You can try to police that future. Or you can **practice** it:

- By telling the truth without theatrics.
- By making beauty under constraint.
- By choosing institutions that make you kinder and smarter than you woul alone.
- By learning to watch while sleeping, to dream without lying, to wake with breaking.

No one is at the wheel. Good. That means the responsibility is shared. And th ours.

Wake carefully.

Dream deliberately.

And let the model you live by be elegant enough to carry the weight of being h

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